.

The Mourning Ride

Background

The old **King's Hollow Road** winds through marsh and mist, a haunted stretch whispered to claim any who linger. Centuries ago, the **Order of Ravencourt** fell here — slaughtered while escorting a noble's supply caravan. When the last knight died clutching his banner, his rage cursed the convoy for eternity.

Now, under a harvest moon, the party must escort their own wagons through this same road. The pay is generous — 500 gp for a quick dawn run — but the fog grows thicker, and faint drums echo in the distance...

Scene 1 – The Fog Descends

Lanterns dim. A horse screams. Pale shapes in rusted armor emerge from the fog — **Haunted Soldiers** still reliving their final orders.

Encounter 1 – Ambush of the Fallen
3 × *Haunted Soldier (CR 2)*
1 × *Spectral Captain (CR 3)*
Tactics:
One soldier appears each round until all three are in play. The Captain manifests on round 3, rallying the others with spectral fury (+3 damage for 1 round).

Environment

- **Fog:** Lightly obscured; ranged attacks > 30 ft have disadvantage.
- **Wagons:** Half-cover; wheels AC 13 HP 20.
- **Fire:** Damaged wagons can ignite (DC 10 DEX check or 1d6 fire/round).

Scene 2 – The Headless Rider

When the Captain's form shatters, a shriek cuts through the mist. A flaming warhorse bursts forth, carrying a knight with no head — the **Headless Rider**, drawn to any who disturb his road.

Encounter 2 – The Headless Rider (CR 5)
When reduced to ½ HP, the Rider's body splits and his **Nightmare steed** continues the fight.

Rewards

Item	Type	Description
Ravencourt Banner Shard	Wondrous (uncommon)	Once per day cast *Protection from Evil and Good* on yourself.
Ashen Medallion	Trinket	Advantage on one save vs fear per long rest.
Spectral Horseshoe	Curio	Glows when undead ≤ 60 ft; can summon a ghostly mount 1 hr (1/day).

Optional Skill Challenge – "Calming the Dead"

Goal: Lay the soldiers to rest before the Rider's second phase.
DC 15, 3 successes before 3 failures
Religion / Arcana / Persuasion / Performance may apply.
Success → Rider dissipates peacefully.
Failure → Phase 2 begins immediately.

Monster Stat Blocks

Haunted Soldier (CR 2)

Medium undead, lawful neutral
Armor Class 16 (chain mail)
Hit Points 50 (8d8 + 16)
Speed 30 ft
STR 15 (+2) DEX 12 (+1) CON 15 (+2) INT 10 (+0) WIS 11 (+0) CHA 10 (+0)
Saving Throws Wis +2
Damage Resistances bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical attacks
Damage Immunities poison
Condition Immunities poisoned, charmed, exhaustion
Senses darkvision 60 ft, passive Perception 10
Languages Common
Challenge 2 (450 XP)

Frightful Glare. Once per turn, one creature within 10 ft must succeed on a DC 12 WIS save or be frightened until the end of its next turn.

Spectral Weapon. This attack counts as magical.

Actions

Longsword. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. *Hit:* 9 (1d10 + 4) slashing damage.

Fade Step (1/Day). The soldier becomes incorporeal until the end of its next turn and may move through creatures and objects as difficult terrain.

Spectral Captain (CR 3)

Medium undead, lawful neutral
Armor Class 17 (spectral plate)
Hit Points 85 (10d8 + 40)
Speed 30 ft
STR 16 (+3) DEX 12 (+1)** CON 18 (+4)** INT 11 (+0)** WIS 12 (+1)** CHA 14 (+2)
Saving Throws Wis +3, Cha +4
Resistances nonmagical damage; Immunities poison
Senses darkvision 60 ft
Challenge 3 (700 XP)

Aura of Terror. Creatures that start their turn within 10 ft must make a DC 13 WIS save or be frightened until end of next turn.

Rally Command (Recharge 5–6). Allied undead within 30 ft gain +3 damage until the Captain's next turn.

Actions

Spectral Blade. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 11 (2d6 + 4) slashing + 7 (2d6) necrotic.

Haunting Strike (1/Day). Each enemy within 10 ft makes a DC 14 CON save or takes 18 (4d8) necrotic and is restrained by spectral chains until the end of its next turn.

Headless Rider (CR 5)

Medium undead, chaotic evil
Armor Class 17 (plate, mounted)
Hit Points 110 (13d8 + 52)
Speed 30 ft (walk), 60 ft (mount)
STR 18 (+4) DEX 14 (+2)** CON 18 (+4)** INT 10 (+0)** WIS 12 (+1)** CHA 14 (+2)
Saving Throws Str +6, Con +6, Wis +3
Resistances nonmagical damage; fire; Immunities poison
Condition Immunities frightened, poisoned
Senses darkvision 60 ft
Challenge 5 (1,800 XP)

Headless Fury. Immune to blindness and charm; advantage on saves vs fear.

Flaming Charge (Recharge 5–6). 30-ft line; DC 15 DEX save or 18 (4d8) fire + prone.

Phase Split. At ½ HP, the Rider and his Nightmare mount separate. The Rider continues on foot (HP 55); the Nightmare acts independently.

Actions

Greatsword. +7 to hit, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 15 (2d10 + 4) slashing + 9 (2d8) necrotic.

Decapitate (1/Day). If the Rider scores a critical hit, target must make a DC 15 CON save or drop to 0 HP.

Nightmare (Spectral Mount)

Use *Monster Manual* Nightmare stats, HP 75. Immune to fire and charmed while the Headless Rider lives.

DM Pacing Tips

- Round 1: 1 Haunted Soldier appears.
- Round 2: 2nd Soldier joins.
- Round 3: Captain arrives (+3 damage aura).
- Round 5 or on Captain's defeat: Headless Rider charges in.
- Use fog, fires, and panicking horses to add chaos.

When the fog finally lifts, let the players see hundreds of helmets buried in the marsh — a silent audience to their victory.

.